Lesson 19: Grammar: Past Tense Verbs and Forming Questions

English Stage 1 (B1) · Unit 2: Getting to Know You

Adapted from Getting to Know You - An Intermediate Integrated-Skills Module for English Learners by Sara Ferguson, Grossmont College (CC BY-NC-SA): 1.6: Grammar: Past Tense Verbs; 1.7: Grammar: Forming Questions; 4.3: Past Tense Practice: Dictogloss Activity.

In this lesson

You will review the simple past and the past continuous with examples from the profiles, including the spelling rules for -ed and -ing. Then you will learn the word order of yes/no questions, information questions and subject questions, write questions about Leslie Reynolds, and retell a short text in the past.

Learning goals

After this lesson you should be able to:

- Spell regular past forms correctly and use common irregular past forms.
- Form the past continuous and use it for an interrupted action or two actions at the same time.
- Form yes/no questions and information (wh-) questions with the correct word order.
- Make subject questions (Who warned the mayor?) and object questions (Who did the scientists warn?).
- Retell a short text in the past tense.

Key language

Word or phrase	Meaning in simple English	Example
simple past	a finished action in the past	Cody Gibson studied photography in Oregon and Colorado.
past continuous	was/were + verb-ing: an action in progress in the past	Cody was studying photography when he decided to change his major.
irregular verb	the past form does not follow one rule	find, found
auxiliary	a helping verb: do, be, have, or a modal (can, will…)	Did Felipe Valdez move to the U.S.?
yes/no question	a question with the answer "yes" or "no"	Has he completed his bachelor's degree?
information question	a wh- question that asks for more information	When did Felipe Valdez move to the U.S.?

Word or phrase	Meaning in simple English	Example
subject question	a question about the subject (no do/does/did)	Who warned the mayor about the meteor?
achievement	the act of reaching a goal	Earning a degree is an achievement.

Rules and explanations

Simple past: form

- Regular verbs: base verb + -ed: decide, decided.
- Irregular verbs do not follow one rule: find, found; eat, ate. Learn them from the list of 90 irregular verbs in your material (base form, past, past participle: go, went, gone).
- Careful: the book's first example says "Eat--eaten". The simple past of "eat" is **ate**. "Eaten" is the past participle (eat, ate, eaten).

Spelling: adding -ed

Rule	Examples
Most verbs: add -ed	walk, walked
Ends in -e: add -d	like, liked; receive, received
Ends in one **stressed** vowel + one consonant (not w, x, y): double the consonant	plan, planned; stop, stopped; re·FER, referred; con·TROL, controlled
Consonant + y: change y to i, add -ed	carry, carried; study, studied; try, tried
Ends in -c: add -ked	picnic, picnicked; traffic, trafficked
All other verbs: add -ed	ski, skied; push, pushed; MAR·ket, marketed; NUM·ber, numbered; explain, explained; play, played; show, showed; tax, taxed

"Market" and "number" end in an **unstressed** syllable, so you do not double the consonant.

Simple past: use

Use it for any completed action in the past: recent or distant, single or repeated.

- When he was a child, Cody attended 17 different schools.
- Last week, he got a job with his dream company.

Past continuous: form and -ing spelling

- Form: was/were + verb-ing. While we were writing a thank you letter, she was sleeping.
- Most verbs and verbs ending in -y: add -ing: read, reading; say, saying; study, studying.
- Ends in -e: drop the -e: wake, waking; make, making.
- Ends in -ie: change -ie to -y and add -ing: die, dying; lie, lying.

- One syllable, consonant-vowel-consonant (not w, x, y): double the last letter: stop, stopping; sit, sitting.
- Two syllables ending consonant-vowel-consonant: double only if the last syllable is stressed: be·GIN, beginning; re·FER, referring. But LIS·ten, listening; CAN·cel, canceling (American spelling; British: cancelling).

Past continuous: use

1. An action in progress is interrupted by another event or a time: When you arrived, we were writing you a letter. The longer action (were writing) is past continuous; the interruption (arrived) is simple past. (The book's answer says "simple present" here; it is simple past.)
2. Two actions in progress at the same time: We were reading while the instructor was writing on the board.

Yes/no questions

Pattern: **auxiliary + subject + main verb + rest**. The auxiliary shows the tense; the main verb shows the aspect.

Statement	Question	Main verb
Felipe Valdez moved to the U.S.	Did Felipe Valdez move to the U.S.?	base form (simple)
He has completed his bachelor's degree.	Has he completed his bachelor's degree?	past participle (perfect)
He is pursuing his career.	Is he pursuing his career?	-ing form (continuous)

- If the main verb is **be**, put be before the subject. Do not add do: He was an excellent student. → Was he an excellent student?
- Careful: two of the book's answers have mistakes. The verb in "Since 2007, he has completed his bachelor's degree" is "has completed" (not "had completed"). In "Is he an excellent student?" the main verb is "is" (not "are").

Information questions

Pattern: **wh- word + auxiliary + subject + main verb + rest**. It is the same order as a yes/no question, with a wh- word at the start. It works for all tenses.

- Did Felipe Valdez move to the U.S.? → When did Felipe Valdez move to the U.S.?
- Was he studying mechanical engineering? → Where was he studying mechanical engineering?
- Why has he become an intern at NASA?

Subject questions

When **who** or **what** is the subject, do not use do/does/did. Use the statement order: who/what + verb + rest.

- The scientists warned the mayor about the meteor.
  - Who warned the mayor about the meteor? (answer: the scientists, the subject)
  - Who did the scientists warn about the meteor? (answer: the mayor, the object)

- With how many, how much, what kind of, which: How many students are attending UC Sacramento? ("how many students" is the subject). How many awards has Felipe won? (object). The verb always agrees with the subject.

> **Note for Arabic speakers** - Arabic questions do not use do/does/did. In English, information questions need the auxiliary before the subject: "Where did he complete his degree?" (not "Where he completed his degree?"). After "did", use the base verb: "Did he move?" (not "Did he moved?").

Practice

1. Two past forms (book). What are the verbs? How is the past formed? a) Cody Gibson studied photography in Oregon and Colorado. b) Cody was studying photography when he decided to change his major.

2. -ed spelling. Write the simple past: walk, receive, stop, control, study, try, picnic, enjoy, number, explain, depend, show.

3. Irregular verbs. Write the simple past. Check with the list of 90 irregular verbs: begin, become, go, grow, make, swim, think, lead, take, hold, sing, eat.

4. Simple past use (book). a) When he was a child, Cody attended 17 different schools. b) Last week, he got a job with his dream company. Which sentence is about the recent past? The distant past? A repeated action? A single action?

5. -ing spelling. Write the -ing form: talk, carry, tape, die, sit, ban, refer, listen, begin, cancel.

6. Past continuous use (book). a) When you arrived, we were writing you a letter. Which action takes longer? Which action interrupts? b) At 10:00 AM, she was walking around her neighborhood. What was she doing when the clock said 10:00 AM? c) We were reading while the instructor was writing on the board. Which action took longer?

7. Yes/no and information questions. Use sentences from the profiles. Make a yes/no question: a) Cody studied photography in Oregon. b) Leslie has worked for the National Park Service for 21 years. c) Felipe is studying mechanical engineering. d) Jennifer was undecided between two colleges. e) Cody was studying photography when he decided to change his major. Now make an information question with the word in brackets: f) (Where) Cody studied photography in Oregon and Colorado. g) (Why) Felipe moved to the U.S. to pursue his education. h) (How many) Cody attended 17 different schools.

8. Subject and object questions. Write a question for each answer in brackets. a) Scientists have studied space for many years. (scientists) (space) b) Dr. Granda inspired Felipe. (Dr. Granda) (Felipe)

9. Questions about Leslie Reynolds (book). Read the Reynolds paragraph in section 1.7 of your material. Write a question for each sentence, starting with the word given. a) Leslie Reynolds began her career at Yosemite National Park. Where...? b) Leslie Reynolds worked as an officer, medic, instructor, investigator, and counselor. How many jobs...? c) Leslie has helped save hikers, climbers, and accident victims. Who...? d) Because she understands the importance of prevention and education,

Leslie developed the PSAR programs. Why…? e) Leslie has worked for the National Park Service for 21 years. How long…?

10. Dictogloss (book, section 4.3). Choose one short reading: Jeannette Rankin, Greta Thunberg or Diana Nyad. Do not read it yet. Discuss its pre-reading questions with your tutor. Then ask your tutor to read it to you slowly three times (or record yourself reading it, and listen the next day without looking). Take notes on the second and third listening. Write a summary in the past tense, then compare it with the text and correct your verbs.

Speak with your tutor

- "Interview me about an achievement I am proud of. Ask past tense questions, one at a time: When did you…? How did you…? What was difficult? Then I will interview you with the same questions. Correct my questions."
- "Give me 8 statements about Felipe Valdez or Cody Gibson. For each one, I will make a yes/no question and a wh- question. Correct my word order."
- "Give me sentences like 'The scientists warned the mayor.' I will make one subject question and one object question for each."
- "Ask me what I was doing at different times yesterday: 'What were you doing at 8 PM?' Then I will ask you the same questions."

Read aloud

1. Did Felipe Valdez move to the U.S.? (↗)
2. When did Felipe Valdez move to the U.S.? (↘)
3. Who warned the mayor about the meteor? (↘)
4. How long has Leslie worked for the National Park Service? (↘)
5. re·FER, referred; con·TROL, controlled; but LIS·ten, listened

Writing task

Write about an achievement (the act of reaching a goal). Examples from the book: completing a difficult class, earning a degree, getting a job, finding an apartment, saving money to buy a house or car, raising a healthy family, learning to cook a special dish.

- First, list three achievements that make you proud.
- Choose one and write a paragraph about it. Describe all the steps you took to achieve your goal. What was difficult?
- Use the simple past for the steps. Use the past continuous at least once (for example, "While I was studying, I was also working.").
- Ask your tutor to check your past tense verbs.

Watch online

- Slide presentation, Past Tense Verbs (from the book): https://docs.google.com/presentation/d/e/2PACX-1vSBCXbsU50iSTG5nua_iq5eCo9VgTdxCylM6Vos_ia8L-zrfTzX-6oFsKIGzUdsqVY6SriHYL_ie6sH/embed
- Slide presentation, Forming Questions (from the book): https://docs.google.com/presentation/d/e/2PACX-1vSRlbXRkdNjkw4viPoEht5gEa5d9Z7zduwsIi8NiHVaMKW1BQucRR3q-gdQR9Gpvo_UyGGhHPjH-osA/embed

Answer key

1. (book) a) "studied": simple past, regular verb. b) "was studying": past continuous; "decided": simple past.

2. (book examples) walked, received, stopped, controlled, studied, tried, picnicked, enjoyed, numbered, explained, depended, showed.

3. (book list) began, became, went, grew, made, swam, thought, led, took, held, sang, ate.

4. (book) Recent past: b. Distant past: a. Repeated action: a. Single action: b.

5. (book examples) talking, carrying, taping, dying, sitting, banning, referring, listening, beginning, canceling (British: cancelling).

6. (book, corrected) a) Writing takes longer; the arrival interrupts it. b) She was walking around her neighborhood. c) We don't know: the two actions happened at the same time.

7. a) Did Cody study photography in Oregon? b) Has Leslie worked for the National Park Service for 21 years? c) Is Felipe studying mechanical engineering? d) Was Jennifer undecided between two colleges? e) Was Cody studying photography when he decided to change his major? f) Where did Cody study photography? g) Why did Felipe move to the U.S.? h) How many schools did Cody attend?

8. a) (book) Who has studied space for many years? / What have scientists studied for many years? b) Who inspired Felipe? / Who did Dr. Granda inspire?

9. (book) a) Where did Leslie Reynolds begin her career? b) How many jobs did Leslie Reynolds do? c) Who has Leslie helped save? d) Why did Leslie develop the PSAR programs? e) How long has Leslie worked for the National Park Service?

10. (example answer, Reading 1) Jeannette Rankin was born in 1880 and grew up in Montana. She graduated from the University of Montana in 1902. After that, she worked for women's right to vote. She stayed in Congress for one term. In 1940 she ran for Congress again and won. She was a pacifist, so she voted against joining World War 1 and World War 2.

My notes